



LISTENING

#05

1 - Instructions: After listening to the audio, answer the following questions based on what you heard. This listening activity is about a visit to the dentist.

Going to the dentist.

1 - How did the dentist greet the patient at the beginning of the visit?

2 - What was the main reason the patient came to see the dentist?

3 - According to the patient, when did the problem with her tooth begin?

4 - What seems to trigger the pain in the patient's tooth?

5 - What procedure or examination did the dentist perform during the appointment?

6 - What instructions or advice did the dentist give the patient during the visit?

7 - What diagnosis did the dentist make after examining the patient's tooth?

8 - What treatment is needed in order to restore the affected tooth?

9 - Was the dental treatment completed during the same visit, or was a follow-up appointment necessary?

10 - What will the dentist use to prevent the patient from feeling pain during the treatment?

Summary of the article **“Fear factor: why cost is the scariest part of going to the dentist in Australia”** from *The Guardian*:

The article explains that Australia’s universal health-care system covers most medical needs but largely excludes dental care, a gap that has led to significant inequalities in access to dental services. When Medicare was introduced, dental services were omitted and most dental costs remain out-of-pocket. Drawing on the Grattan Institute’s *Filling the Gap* report, the piece argues for a universal dental scheme and highlights that more than 2 million Australians—about 18 percent of those who needed care—delayed or skipped dental appointments in the previous year because of cost. Income is a strong determinant of whether people miss dental appointments. Contrary to the common belief that fear drives avoidance, the report shows that cost is the main deterrent for low- and median-income earners. Only 19 percent of median-income Australians avoid dentists because of fear, whereas 57 percent cite cost, and two-thirds of low-income Australians also blame cost for missing visits. Avoiding dental care has long-term health consequences; for example, people aged 45–64 earning \$30,000 per year have lost twice as many teeth as those earning more than \$140,000. Australians visit the dentist less often than residents of New Zealand, Canada and the UK, and among wealthy nations only the United States has lower rates of dentist visits. Existing public dental programmes are highly targeted and means-tested, leaving less than half of adults in the bottom two income deciles eligible for assistance. The Grattan report calls for a universal dental scheme that would remove financial barriers by requiring dentists to charge fees based on an agreed schedule without extra patient payments. Such a scheme would cost around \$5.6 billion per year. The report proposes first fully funding existing public dental programmes—requiring an extra \$1.1 billion annually—and then gradually expanding coverage to all social welfare recipients and children, aiming for universal coverage within a decade. Workforce challenges include a limited number of dentists per capita; Australia has fewer dentists than many other OECD countries and must train more professionals while recognising internationally trained practitioners. Many dentists work part-time, which could help absorb increased demand. The article notes that for more than 40 years dental care has been considered too costly and difficult to include in Medicare, leading to worsening inequalities. It concludes that universal health care is incomplete without dental services and that excluding dental care condemns low-income people to poorer health and quality of life.

Article – *Fear factor: why cost is the scariest part of going to the dentist in Australia* (Greg Jericho, *The Guardian*, 25 March 2019)

COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS

1 - According to the Grattan Institute’s findings, what proportion of Australians who needed dental care delayed or skipped their visits because of cost?

2 - How does income level affect Australians’ likelihood of missing dental appointments, and what percentage of median-income earners cited cost as the main reason for avoiding the dentist?

3 - What evidence does the article provide to challenge the idea that fear is the main reason people avoid going to the dentist?

4 - What financial costs and workforce challenges does the article mention in relation to implementing a universal dental scheme in Australia?

5 - Why does the article argue that universal healthcare is incomplete without including dental care?